Almost everybody who interacted with Kaul at the time remembers him as being quite extraordinary. Since the 8 September Dhola crisis had begun to unfold, most officers in Army HQ who could see the absurdity of what was happening kept lamenting that in Kaul's absence, the acting CGS and the COAS had completely overreacted and created a situation that was logistically impossible to execute. Given Kaul's penchant to dash off to the front, it was believed that he would have made the effort to get to Niranjan Prasad and Dalvi, which would have allowed him to arrive at a more realistic picture. But then again, all those who had interacted with Kaul also remember him as being pompous and vain, something that would come across even in the briefest of meetings.

The fact that Menon knew Kaul so well allowed him to bait the hook and it was a matter of seconds before the CGS was attached to his line. Nehru did have to make a show of first cajoling and then ordering the general to take on the job. The plan to create an ad hoc formation, IV Corps, to be headquartered at Tezpur was then worked out. Kaul would now be moving down in the hierarchy by two steps by relinquishing the post of CGS and becoming a corps commander. But it was a small price to pay if it allowed him the opportunity to emerge as the hero who had defeated the Chinese. The fact that Kaul would be functioning as the head of a corps that had only two measly brigades under its command was ignored, as was the fact that Kaul would now, at least notionally, be under the command of Bogey Sen.

At 9 p.m. on 3 October, Lieutenant General B. M. Bijji Kaul was formally informed that he had been appointed as commander IV Corps with the specific aim of evicting the Chinese from the Dhola area and pushing them off the Thagla Ridge.

If Kaul had had any reservations, they had evaporated by the morning of 4 October and his vanity had taken over the situation. He started the day by meeting with Prem Bhatia, the editor of the *Times of India*. Soon after Kaul was driven to Palam Airport by his DMO. Wrote Palit subsequently: 'I asked whether he felt justified in vacating the CGS's chair just to go and "take command of a couple of brigades?"… He replied, somewhat defensively, that he would soon be given more troops as other divisions would be sent to him and that eventually his corps would command the whole frontier from the Uttar Pradesh Himalayas to the Burma border… It was a crucial responsibility…given him by the Prime Minister himself.